

Just enter the command **tracert** and the IP address.

There are also a number of online tools as well as software (see box, 'Armed for Defence') that help you do a Traceroute on an IP address such as www.samspace.org/t/, or portscanning utilities at www.nscan.hypermart.net. One of the best Traceroute tools is available at <http://network-tools.com>.

Running a Traceroute will track the route of IP addresses of the servers that the e-mail went through to get to your e-mail account. You can look up all the IP addresses and do a 'whois' look up to trace the e-mail to the host.

A red herring

Tracing an e-mail won't always lead directly to the culprit. Often, the actual location of a computer will not match the 'whois' information.

On the Net, it's very easy to forge e-mail addresses and headers. Several online tools such as Anonymisers, Remailers and other software allow people to cover their tracks and wipe out all trace of Internet activity while sending an e-mail or spam.

In certain cases, IP addresses can also be 'spoofed' or forged to cover up the culprit's tracks. This happens mostly in hacking cases and rarely with anonymous e-mail.

At best, tracing an e-mail will take you to an ISP that has its own e-mail address, or you could go through their logs and find out the location of the person who sent you the mail.

"It could lead you to a company proxy server connected to a corporate LAN," says Flynn Remedios from Cyber-Forensics India, an organisation that assists the Mumbai Cyber Crime cell in investigating cases. He adds, "It's difficult to pinpoint the computer out of the several on the company LAN that the e-mail originated from. Proxy servers maintain a log of all Internet activity within that location."

But hold on! You can't just walk in and ask for ISP logs or logs of the proxy server. At the most, you can complain to the ISP. You also can't ask a company to

Who can Help you?



I. M. ZAHID
CYBER CRIME CELL, MUMBAI

You've received a spate of disturbing e-mail and don't know whom to turn to. Well, one place that you can count on to take some action is the Cyber Crime Cell of the

Mumbai and Bangalore police.

According to the IT Act chalked out in 2000, certain acts performed online such as hacking, denial of service, spoofing, spamming, pornography, cyber harassment or cyber stalking by e-mail, IRC chat or Usenet, credit card fraud and online fraud, are considered punishable crimes and persons found breaking the law can be arrested, fined or imprisoned.

The Cyber Crime Cell at Mumbai, part of the Economic Offences Wing of the Greater Mumbai Police, was inaugurated on December 18, 2000, to deal with the enforcement of cyber laws. (For more information check out www.ccic-mumbai.com). The Cyber Crime Cell works along with a technical committee

and an advisory committee that include Vijay Mukhi and Amitabh Kumar (Director - Operations, VSNL), to help nab cyber-crooks.

According to Inspector I. M. Zahid of the Cyber Crime Cell, every cyber crime leaves behind a trail of evidence, which can be tracked from the destination machine to the machine from where an offensive mail was sent, or the machine a hacker used to break into a system.

"The important thing is to deconstruct the crime and build a concrete trail of evidence so that the case can be presented in a court of law and withstand judicial scrutiny," adds Zahid.

"In cases of cyber harassment, most victims are women and the person the mail originates from is often someone who's known to the victim, like an ex-fiancé or ex-boyfriend seeking revenge." He adds that there has been a spurt in e-mail crime and a fairly good percentage of detection.

When you receive an anonymous or offensive e-mail and need to report it, preserving a copy of the e-mail in your inbox is very important as that's physical evidence of the crime and will help the cops trace the culprit.

do anything about e-mail that originated from their mail server.

Report it!

Here's where the benefits of reporting a cyber crime to the police come in. The police can investigate and handle the tracing of your e-mail as well as ask the ISP, or anyone, for logs to find out the physical location of the person who's harassing you.

"But they can only do this if the person who's being harassed has lodged a formal complaint," says Remedios. The police too have their share of problems trying to track down cyber crime offenders. "In most cases the computer that is used in either hacking or a cyber crime is located at a cyber cafe," says Inspector I. M. Zahid. "Cyber cafes don't keep a

record of the people using the computers there, which adds to the problem of tracing cyber crime culprits." Additionally, the most important factor is collecting proof of the crime committed, which is extremely difficult to do if the crime is committed from a cyber cafe.

"The most important advantage of going to the cops rather than trying to trace the mail on your own is the complete anonymity and protection of your identity," says Remedios.

So the next time you receive spam or anonymous mail from someone you don't know, it would help to know a thing or two about protecting yourself online. But if you really want bring the culprits to book, call the cyber cops! 

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